

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1993-06-24

To the b ahá'ís of the w orld

1 dearly loved f riends,

following fast upon the inspiring events of the seventh international

2 bahá'í convention and the subsequent counselors' conference, the open-
3 ing weeks of the Three year plan have been marked with yet another highly
4 significant event. on the morning of Saturday 5 june, the hands of the
5 cause of god 'Alí Akbar furútan and 'Alí-m uḤammad varqá, with all nine
6 counselor members of the international Teaching center, joined the mem-
7 of bahá'u'lláh for prayer as the initial act of the newly appointed Teaching
8 center. All then held a first meeting in the room used by Shoghi effendi
9 in the mansion of bahjí, recalling the many historic associations of that
10 blessed spot.

11 joint consultations continued on the afternoon of that same day in the
12 facing the international Teaching center as the world advances through the
13 climacteric years at the close of the twentieth century.

14 during the five years since may 1988, when far-reaching decisions were
15 made on the functioning of the international Teaching center and, for the
16 first time, the number of its counselor members was raised to nine, that
17 institution has abundantly demonstrated its capacity and eagerness to as-
18 sume the wide range of responsibilities conferred upon it.

19 The clarification of various approaches to the teaching work which the
20 Teaching center has issued, its indication of potentially fruitful methods
21 and fields of endeavor, and the collaboration of the counselors with the
22 National Spiritual Assemblies in the formulation of their goals for the Three
23 year plan have contributed immeasurably to the deepening of the under-157 .1

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158 1993–1996 • T h e T h r e e Y e a r P l a n

159 7standing of the individual believers; the teaching, enrollment and inspirit-
160 ing of children and youth; the consolidation of growing communities; the
161 strengthening of their institutions; and unflagging pursuit of the expansion
162 of the cause.

163 The Teaching center's former duties relating to the formulation of plans
164 for our approval have undergone a change as a result of the devolution of
165 planning upon National Spiritual Assemblies which was a mark of the open-
166 ing of the fourth epoch of the formative Age. we have been most favorably
167 impressed by the guidance it has given to the continental counselors to
168 promote consultation at the local and national levels, among institutions
169 and believers, leading to the initiation and sustaining of processes of growth

in the bahá'í community, and we look forward to the perpetuation and

170 expansion of this collaboration.

The responsibility of the continental boards of counselors to protect

171 the faith, under the guidance of the international Teaching center, will
172 undoubtedly gain greater importance in the years ahead. They will encour-age and
assist the National and local Spiritual Assemblies, not only to deal
173 with questions on the faith raised by interested non-b ahá'ís, but also to
174 counter attacks launched by external opponents.

175 Study of the faith itself is a vital element in the soundness of the growth

of bahá'í communities, their consolidation and their protection. This

176 should include systematic study of the writings of the faith, its history, its
177 relationship to various systems of thought, and the application of its Teach-ings to the
spiritual and material life of society. The international Teaching
178 center will contribute significantly to the advancement of such study.
179 in the production and dissemination of bahá'í literature, which is funda-
180 mental to both the expansion and consolidation of the cause, the support

181 given by the counselors to National Assemblies through the literature Sub-
182 vention fund and especially the Teaching center's promotion of the core
183 literature concept have resulted in an admirable surge forward, and we are confident
that this effort will be augmented in the years ahead.

184 The flow of pioneers and traveling teachers has been notably increased

through the development of the continental pioneer committees under

185 the aegis of the international Teaching center, as well as by the actions of
186 the continental counselors and National Assemblies. it has become appar-
187 ent that, with the growth of the bahá'í world and the increased mobility of
188 the friends, new methods are required for advising and routing pioneers. The
pioneering call for the Three year plan therefore assumes a character 157 .5

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158 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

159 8different from that to which the friends have been accustomed and will, we
160 confidently expect, permit a far more fruitful use of the energies and devo-
161 tion of the friends.

All the above matters were among the subjects of consultation between

their meetings on 5 june, and during a subsequent meeting towards the

162 close of the intensive consultations carried on by the Teaching center itself.

163 The five members who are still resident abroad are now preparing to move
164 to the h o l y l a n d.

165 it is our fervent prayer at the Sacred Threshold that these developments

166 will impart a yet greater impetus to the activities of the individual believers and their
institutions throughout the world and accelerate the work already so eagerly launched for
the achievement of the Three y e a r p l a n.

167 with loving b a h á ' í greetings,

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Visit to the Bahá'í World Center of Deputy Prime

Minister of Papua New Guinea

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]